

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

----- X

NATASIA GARNER,

Plaintiff,

**SUMMONS TO THE
VERIFIED COMPLAINT**

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK; P.O. ALEX TORRES, Shield # 27260; P.O. LARS PIHLAVA, Shield # 11039; P.O. STEPHANIE CASTILLO, Shield # 30685; P.O. BRYN MIET, Shield # 4508, and P.O. JOHN DOES # 1-5, the individual defendant(s) sued individually and in their official capacities,

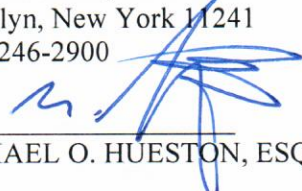
Index:Basis of Venue: occurrence of incident: 182nd Street between Prospect Avenue and Clinton Avenue, Bronx, New York

Defendants.

----- X

To the above named defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your answer or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the plaintiff's attorney within twenty days after service of this summons exclusive of the day of service where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or within thirty days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: Brooklyn, New York
January 6, 2017MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
16 Court Street, Suite 3301
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 246-2900
By: 

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.

Defendants' addresses: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, 100 Church Street, New York, New York 10007; and P.O. ALEX TORRES, Shield # 27260; P.O. LARS PIHLAVA, Shield # 11039; P.O. STEPHANIE CASTILLO, Shield # 30685; P.O. BRYN MIET, Shield # 4508, and P.O. JOHN DOES # 1-5, 48th Precinct, 450 Cross Bronx Expy, Bronx, NY 10457

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

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NATASIA GARNER,

Plaintiff,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK; P.O. ALEX TORRES, Shield # 27260; P.O. LARS PIHLAVA, Shield # 11039; P.O. STEPHANIE CASTILLO, Shield # 30685; P.O. BRYN MIET, Shield # 4508, and P.O. JOHN DOES # 1-5, the individual defendant(s) sued individually and in their official capacities,

Defendants.
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VERIFIED COMPLAINT

Index:

Basis of Venue: occurrence of incident: 182nd Street between Prospect Avenue and Clinton Avenue, Bronx, New York

Plaintiff Natasia Garner, by and through her counsel, Michael O. Hueston, Esq. and Steven Z. Legon, Esq., upon information and belief, alleges as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights, common law, and tort action in which plaintiff seeks relief for the violation of plaintiff's rights secured by 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth, Sixth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution; and the laws of the State of New York. Plaintiff's claims arise from an incident that occurred on or about October 9, 2015. During the incident, the City of New York, and members of the New York City Police Department ("NYPD") subjected plaintiff to, among other things: false arrest; assault; battery; unreasonable force; failure to intervene; conspiracy; denial of a fair trial/fabricated evidence; implementation and continuation of an unlawful municipal policy, practice, and custom; and respondeat superior liability. Plaintiff seeks compensatory and punitive damages, declaratory

relief, an award of costs and attorney's fees, pursuant 42 U.S.C. § 1988, and such other and further relief as the Court deems just and proper.

JURISDICTION & VENUE

2. Within 90 days of the incident alleged in this complaint, plaintiff served upon defendant City of New York a Notice of Claim setting forth the name and post office addresses of plaintiff, the nature of the claims, the time when, the place where and the manner in which the claims arose, and the items of damages or injuries claimed.

3. More than 30 days have elapsed since plaintiff's demands and/or claims were presented to defendant City of New York for adjustment and/or payment thereof, and the defendant has neglected and/or refused to make any adjustment and/or payment.

4. Defendant City of New York has not requested a physical examination of Plaintiff. Plaintiff is available to participate in a 50-H hearing after the termination of her criminal case. Plaintiff has signed and provided the City of New York with a stipulation regarding commencing this action against the City of New York prior to a 50-h Hearing and being required to notify the City of New York of the resolution of plaintiff's pending criminal charges. This action is being commenced within one year and ninety days of the date of the occurrences herein.

5. Venue is proper in the Supreme Court of the State of New York, Bronx County, because the acts in question occurred in the State of New York, Bronx County, and the City of New York is subject to personal jurisdiction in Supreme Court of the State New York, Bronx County; and jurisdiction is proper because the Supreme Court of the State New York,

Bronx County has jurisdiction over plaintiff's state law causes of actions, and plaintiff's federal causes of action pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1983.

PARTIES

6. Plaintiff Natasia Garner is a resident of the State of New York, living at 735 East 182nd Street, Apt. # 3C, Bronx, New York 10457.

7. At all times herein, defendant City of New York is a municipal corporation organized under the laws of the State of New York, which violated plaintiff's rights as described herein.

8. At all times relevant, defendant City of New York maintained a police department known as the NYPD, which employed the individual defendants.

9. At all times alleged herein, defendants P.O. Alex Torres, Shield # 27260; P.O. Lars Pihlava, Shield # 11039; P.O. Stephanie Castillo, Shield # 30685; P.O. Bryn Miet, Shield # 4508, and P.O. John Does # 1-5 were employed as police officers with 48th Precinct, located in Bronx County, New York, or other as yet unknown NYPD assignment, who violated plaintiff's rights as described herein.

10. The individual defendants are sued in their individual and official capacities.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

The Incident

11. On October 9, 2015, at and in the vicinity of 182nd Street between Prospect Avenue and Clinton Avenue, Bronx, New York, several police officers operating from the 48th Precinct located in Bronx County, New York, including upon information and belief, the individual defendants P.O. Alex Torres, Shield # 27260; P.O. Lars Pihlava, Shield # 11039; P.O.

Stephanie Castillo, Shield # 30685; P.O. Bryn Miet, Shield # 4508, and P.O. John Does # 1-5 (“the police”), at times acting in concert and at times acting independently, committed the following illegal acts against plaintiff.

12. On October 9, 2015 at approximately 4:20 p.m., at and in the vicinity of 182nd Street between Prospect Avenue and Clinton Avenue, Bronx, New York, the police without either consent, an arrest warrant, a lawful search warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff (or any third person) had committed a crime unlawfully arrested plaintiff.

13. Plaintiff was at her home located at 735 East 182nd Street, Bronx, New York when she heard gunshots from her window.

14. Plaintiff’s cousin had been shot and wounded on the street in the vicinity of 182nd Street between Prospect Avenue and Clinton Avenue, Bronx, New York.

15. Plaintiff left her apartment to help her cousin.

16. When plaintiff arrived at the scene, she assisted her cousin by, among other things, having him lay down.

17. Plaintiff also went to a nearby store to get her cousin water.

18. Plaintiff’s other family members arrived at the scene.

19. Plaintiff gave her cousin the water.

20. Plaintiff then left and brought her cousin’s mother back to the scene.

21. The police were now at the scene.

22. Plaintiff and her family inquired about her cousin, including the lack of care he was receiving as he was actively bleeding.

23. The police were rude and abusive to plaintiff and her family.

24. Then police without cause or justification shoved and were rude to plaintiff.

25. When plaintiff complained about the police's conduct, the police set upon her, including shoving her, striking her, placing her in handcuffs, and placing her in a headlock.

26. As the police placed plaintiff in a police vehicle, they struck her head against the car door.

27. At the 48th Precinct, the police continued to abuse plaintiff by, among other things, squeezing the cuffs on her wrists, taunting her, grabbing her by the back of the neck, placing a knee in her back when she fell to the ground, placing shackles on her ankles, and pulling her hair.

28. The police kept plaintiff handcuffed in a cell for many hours.

29. Plaintiff asked for medical treatment and for the cuffs to be loosened, but the police ignored her requests.

30. The police transported plaintiff to Bronx Central Booking for arraignment.

31. Upon information and belief, in order to cover up their illegal actions, the police, pursuant to a conspiracy, initiated by false sworn complaint(s) and/or conversations, falsely and maliciously told the Bronx County District Attorney's Office that plaintiff had committed various crimes, and the District Attorney prosecuted plaintiff for various charges.

32. Plaintiff was released on her own recognizance at arraignment.

33. The criminal case is currently open.

34. Plaintiff was humiliated and embarrassed by the experience.

35. Plaintiff suffered financial loss.

36. Plaintiff suffered physical injuries.

General Allegations

37. Plaintiff did not resist arrest at any time during the above-described incidents.

38. Plaintiff did not violate any law, regulation, or administrative code; commit any criminal act; or act in a suspicious or unlawful manner prior to or during the above-described incident.

39. The individual defendants did not observe plaintiff violate any law, regulation, or administrative code; commit any criminal act; or act in a suspicious or unlawful manner prior to or during the above-described incident.

40. The individual defendants acted under pretense and color of state law and their individual and official capacities and within the scope of their employment. Said acts by said defendants were beyond the scope of their jurisdiction, without authority or law, and in abuse of their powers, and said defendants acted willfully, knowingly, and with the specific intent to deprive plaintiff of her rights.

41. As a direct and proximate result of defendants' actions, plaintiff experienced personal and physical injuries, pain and suffering, fear, an invasion of privacy, psychological pain, emotional distress, mental anguish, embarrassment, humiliation, and financial loss.

42. Plaintiff is entitled to receive punitive damages from the individual defendants because the individual defendants' actions were motivated by extreme recklessness and indifference to plaintiff's rights.

FIRST CLAIM

(FALSE ARREST UNDER FEDERAL LAW)

43. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

44. Defendants falsely arrested plaintiff without consent, an arrest warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime.

45. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for false arrest under 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

SECOND CLAIM

(FALSE ARREST UNDER STATE LAW)

46. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

47. Defendants falsely arrested plaintiff without consent, an arrest warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime.

48. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for false arrest under New York State law.

THIRD CLAIM

(UNREASONABLE FORCE)

49. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

50. The individual defendants' use of force upon plaintiff was objectively unreasonable.

51. The individual defendant officers did not have an objective and/or reasonable basis to use any degree of force against plaintiff.

52. Those defendants who did not touch plaintiff, witnessed these acts, but failed to intervene and protect plaintiff from this conduct.

53. Accordingly, the defendants are liable to plaintiff for using unreasonable force, pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

FOURTH CLAIM

(ASSAULT)

54. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

55. Among other things as described above, individual defendants' battery, false arrest, and unreasonable use of force against plaintiff placed her in fear of imminent harmful and offensive physical contacts.

56. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff under New York State law for assault.

FIFTH CLAIM

(BATTERY)

57. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

58. Among other things as described above, the individual defendants' false arrest, and unreasonable use of force against plaintiff were illegal physical contacts.

59. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff under New York State law for battery.

SIXTH CLAIM

(FAILURE TO INTERVENE)

60. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

61. Defendants had a reasonable opportunity to prevent the violations of plaintiff's constitutional rights, but they failed to intervene.

62. Accordingly, the defendants are liable to plaintiff for failing to intervene to prevent the violation of plaintiff's constitutional rights under 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

SEVENTH CLAIM

(CONSPIRACY)

63. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

64. Defendants are liable to plaintiff because they agreed to act in concert to inflict an unconstitutional injury; and committed an overt act done in furtherance of that goal causing damage to plaintiff under 42 U.S.C. § 1983.

EIGHTH CLAIM

(DENIAL OF A FAIR TRIAL/FABRICATION OF EVIDENCE)

65. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

66. The individual defendants are liable to plaintiff because they intentionally conspired to fabricate evidence against plaintiff, including omitting and/or manipulating evidence, and suppressing exculpatory evidence and forwarded that false evidence to police officers, prosecutors, and the court.

67. The individual defendants violated the law by either testifying falsely, providing false information, and/or drafting and signing false criminal court complaints and/or false police reports and forwarding them to police officers, prosecutors and the court.

68. The individual defendants were on notice that creating fabricated evidence is a clear violation of law because it is well established that individuals who knowingly use false evidence to obtain a conviction act unconstitutionally, depriving plaintiff of liberty without due process of law or a fair trial, and the harm occasioned by such unconscionable actions are redressable in an action for damages under 42 U.S.C. § 1983, the Fair Trial Clause of the Sixth Amendment to the United States Constitution, and the Due Process Clause of the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

NINTH CLAIM

(MONELL CLAIM)

69. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

70. Defendant City of New York, through a policy, practice and custom, directly caused the constitutional violations suffered by plaintiff.

71. Defendant City of New York through the NYPD and its officers, committed the following unconstitutional practices, customs and policies against plaintiff: (1)

wrongfully arresting innocent persons in order to meet productivity goals; and (2) using unreasonable force on individuals.

72. Upon information and belief, defendant City of New York, at all relevant times, was aware that the defendants were unfit officers who have previously committed the acts alleged herein, have a propensity for unconstitutional conduct, or have been inadequately trained.

73. Nevertheless, defendant City of New York exercised deliberate indifference by failing to take remedial action. The City failed to properly train, retrain, supervise, discipline, and monitor the individual defendants and improperly retained and utilized them. Moreover, upon information and belief, defendant City of New York failed to adequately investigate prior complaints filed against the individual defendants.

74. Further, defendant City of New York was aware prior to the incident that the individual defendants (in continuation of its illegal custom, practice and/or policy) would stop, arrest and prosecute innocent individuals, based on pretexts and false evidence.

75. The existence of the aforesaid unconstitutional customs and policies may be inferred from repeated occurrences of similar wrongful conduct involving the individual defendants, placing the defendant City of New York on notice of the individual defendants' propensity to violate the rights of individuals.

TENTH CLAIM

(RESPONDEAT SUPERIOR)

76. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

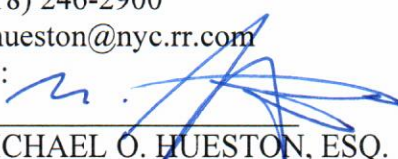
77. The individual defendants were acting within the scope of their employment when they committed the above described acts against plaintiff, including falsely arresting, assaulting, and battering plaintiff.

78. The City of New York is therefore vicariously liable under New York State law for the aforesaid torts.

WHEREFORE, plaintiff demands a jury trial and the following relief jointly and severally against the defendants; and demands judgment and compensatory damages, individually and/or collectively in an amount that exceeds the jurisdiction of all lower courts that would otherwise have jurisdiction as to the above-stated cause of action against all defendants; punitive damages in an amount to be determined at trial as and for the above-stated causes of action against the individual defendants; together with costs and disbursements of this action and legal fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988.

DATED: Brooklyn, New York
January 6, 2017

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
16 Court Street, Suite 3301
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 246-2900
mhueston@nyc.rr.com

By: 

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.

STEVEN Z. LEGON, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
20 Vesey Street
New York, New York 10007
(212) 791-3919
(917) 803-8281
slegon@aol.com

VERIFICATION

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ., an attorney at law, duly admitted to the Bar of the State of New York, affirms under penalties of perjury pursuant to CPLR § 2106 to the truth of the following:

I am the attorney for plaintiff Natasia Garner in the within action. I have read the forgoing COMPLAINT and know the contents thereof; the same is true to my own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged on information and belief, as to those matters I believe them to be true. I make this verification instead of the plaintiff pursuant to CPLR § 3020 because the plaintiff resides in a different county than where I maintain my office.

The grounds for my belief as to all matters in the complaint not stated to be upon my knowledge are based upon conversations with plaintiff, and a review of records related to this action.

Dated: Brooklyn, New York
January 6, 2017

A handwritten signature in blue ink, consisting of a stylized 'M' followed by a series of loops and a long horizontal stroke.

Michael O. Hueston, Esq.

Index No.

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
BRONX COUNTY

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Plaintiff,

-against-

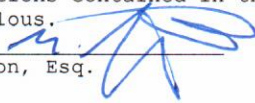
CITY OF NEW YORK, et al.,

Defendants.

SUMMONS AND VERIFIED COMPLAINT

MICHAEL HUESTON, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
16 Court St., Suite 3301
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 246-2900

Pursuant to 22 NYCRR 130-1.1, the undersigned, an attorney duly admitted to practice law in the State of New York, certifies that, upon information and belief based upon reasonable inquiry, the contentions contained in the annexed document are not frivolous.

Dated: 1/6/2017 Signature: 
Michael Hueston, Esq.

*Due and timely, service is hereby
admitted.*

Brooklyn, New York....., 2017

....., *Esq.*

Attorney for.....